

Belarus



Area 80,155 sq miles
(207,600 sq km)
Population 9.6 million
Capital Minsk
Currency Belarussian rouble
Official languages Russian
and Belarussian
Life expectancy 71 years

Belarus literally means “white Russia.” White is a color associated in Slavic culture with freedom and the name may be a reference to the fact that the country was never conquered by the Mongols in the 13th century. Belarus was part of the USSR until 1991. Most people here speak Russian, and only 11 percent of the population are fluent in Belarussian, which is used mainly in rural areas. Plans to construct a nuclear power plant were postponed after the 1986 Chernobyl disaster, which occurred in nearby Ukraine, but are now underway again. Currently, the country is heavily dependent on Russia for fuel and energy supplies.

Ukraine



Area 233,090 sq miles
(603,700 sq km)
Population 45.2 million
Capital Kiev
Currency Hryvnya
Official language Ukrainian
Life expectancy 68 years

The word Ukraine translates as “on the border.” It was long considered merely a fringe of the Russian Empire, but since the collapse of the USSR in 1991 it has been an independent state and is now the second-largest country in Europe after Russia. The country is divided between the Ukrainian-speaking west and a large ethnic Russian population in the east. Ukraine has vast natural resources, including natural gas, oil, and titanium. In 1986, the world's worst nuclear disaster occurred at the Ukraine's Chernobyl power plant. A massive plume of radioactive particles spread across Europe, polluting the environment and raising fears for the long-term health of thousands of people.

Russian Federation



Area 6,592,772 sq miles
(17,075,200 sq km)
Population 143 million
Capital Moscow
Currency Russian rouble
Official language Russian
Life expectancy 66 years

The Russian Federation was formed in 1991, after the USSR collapsed. Bounded by the Arctic and Pacific Oceans to the north and east, it is by far the world's largest country. Ethnic Russians make up four-fifths of the population. However, there are around 150 smaller ethnic groups, many with their own national territories within Russia's borders. Russia has some of the world's largest reserves of key resources

such as gold, diamonds, and timber. It is a major producer of oil, natural gas, and electricity, and launched the world's first floating nuclear power station in 2010 to provide electricity to remote areas. Russia is one of the fastest-growing economies in the world.

► **ST. BASIL'S CATHEDRAL**
With its multicolored, domed towers, St. Basil's Cathedral in Red Square, Moscow, is one of Russia's biggest tourist attractions.

